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The objectification of female nudity in Greek Art: An analysis of male and female greek sculptures and the distinctions between the two

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ABSTRACT

This project seeks to explore the depiction of female nudity in greek art, specifically, sculptures and conduct a comparative study of the same with the depiction of male nudity. Additionally, it aims to investigate whether this depiction was rooted in voyeurism or could it perhaps be an indicator of a progressive society — by analysing the treatment of women in greek society and placing it in context of the artwork produced in that time period. A cursory timeline — beginning from the pottery styles belonging to the Geometric era — followed by Archaic, Classical and Hellenistic period, is drawn wherein early artworks are briefly analysed. Subsequently, the concept of heroic nudity is discussed to lay in the base for comparison of male and female nudes with the help of case studies, namely : Aphrodite of Knidos, Aphrodite of Delos, Venus de Medici and Capitoline Venus. Lastly, the paper discusses the influence of depiction of nudity in greek art on Renaissance and contemporary art.

INTRODUCTION

The cultural values of the Greeks were centered around the exaltation of humanity as the “measure of all things,” It has been said that the Greeks made their gods into humans and their humans into gods and it was only the immortality of the gods that differentiated them from humans. Greek gods were considered to be perfect in their bodily forms and hence the perfect individual became the Greek ideal, making the portrayal of beautiful humans the focus of many of the greatest Greek artists.

This humanistic worldview eventually led to nudity becoming a characteristic of Greek civilization and was frequent in places such as gymnasiums and competitions. The Greek civilization initially, due to its conservative nature, only allowed practicing nudity for religious rituals but a shift into the Archaic age saw nudity being accepted publicly. According to Thucydides, a great ancient historian of the 5th century BCE, it was the Spartans who set the example of competing naked at games; they often stripped off to anoint themselves and to exercise . In Greek the word Gymnos means naked however in a military context gymnos meant "unarmed" and "light-armed," as opposed to the heavy-armed hoplite. By far the most common usage, however, was specifically "exercising in the nude." The word Gymnasium denoted public spaces where one was expected to be naked. This custom of athletic nudity was seen as a display of power and perfection of the male form.

While nudity was seen as a mark of shame in neighbouring countries and was only forced upon prisoners and outlaws as a punishment, the Greeks viewed it as a respectable costume This difference was one of the factors that marked the contrast between Greeks and Non-Greeks and even between men and women of the Athenian society.

Nudity in men conferred their power, their strong body and equally strong mind (*Ibid*). The *Pyrrhic* dance, an integral part of the preparation for war, had to be performed without any

clothes and armour. This nakedness was the dress, one might almost say the uniform, of the citizen who exercised in order to maintain himself in readiness for battles.

Nudity for women was seen as a loss of innocence and could only be practised by *hetairai*, who were Greek prostitutes, who offered their bodies as well as their minds in symposiums full of men. Nudity for a wife of a noble on other hand was a taboo and there is even evidence to suggest that Athenian men rarely saw their wives completely naked, and that Athenian wives wore wraps even during sexual intercourse with their husbands.

There is little to no doubt that nudity was involved with the religious atmosphere of the games and athletics. At the sanctuary at Olympia, as elsewhere, nakedness was an initiation motif at the initiation rites of youths, athletic and artistic competitions which had religious significance. Women, too, participated in ritual nakedness in the course of initiations into special cults or as preparation for marriage and the private life of child-bearing and a family, and therefore it did not develop further as a feature of Greek public life and culture.

The chronology of sculpture in Ancient Greece is traditionally divided into three main periods:

- **The Archaic Period (c.650-500 BCE):** Greek sculptors start to develop monumental marble sculpture.



Kleobis and Biton, kouroi of the Archaic period, c. 580 BC. Delphi Archaeological Museum.

Greek sculptures developed more rapidly during the Archaic Period. A key feature of the Archaic period was the renewal of commercial contacts and maritime trade links between Greece and the Middle East (especially Egypt, as well as the city-states of Asia Minor),

which inspired Greek artists to begin establishing a tradition of monumental marble sculpture.

During the Archaic and Classical periods, most important Greek sculpture was of a religious character, made for temples which were usually dedicated to a single divinity. Divine statues were sculpted in the likeness of man, and were made in various materials and sizes. Other votive statues stood inside and outside the temple as well as urns, images of sacred animals, and other objects of a sculptural nature.

Creativity and innovation took many forms during the sixth century B.C. The earliest known Greek scientist, Thales of Miletos, demonstrated the cycles of nature and successfully predicted a solar eclipse and the solstices. Meanwhile, potters (both native and foreign-born) mastered Corinthian techniques in Athens, and by 550 B.C., Athenian—also called “Attic” for the region around Athens—black-figure pottery dominated the export market throughout the Mediterranean region.

- **The Classical Period (c.500-323 BCE): The creative highpoint of Greek sculpture**



Riace bronzes, examples of proto classic bronze sculpture, Museo Nazionale della Magna Grecia, Reggio Calabria

The art of the Classical Greek style is characterized by a joyous freedom of movement, freedom of expression, and it celebrates mankind as an independent entity (atomo).

The main characteristics of Classical statuary concerned the accuracy of its anatomy and the realism of its stance. The Classical period witnessed a rapid improvement in Greek statuary. There was a dramatic rise in the technical skills of Greek sculptors in their ability to depict the human body in a relaxed rather than rigid posture. Classicism improved on the rigidity of the Archaic idiom and brought a more natural sense of movement and corporeality to the human figure, as exemplified, for instance, in the metopes and pediments of the Temple of Zeus at Olympia. Bronze became the predominant medium for monumental free-standing statues, not least because of the metal's ability to hold its shape, enabling the creation of less rigid poses.

Classicist sculpture continued to be primarily connected with religion, and included the full panoply of Greek divinities and mythological figures. Thus, in addition to the twelve Olympian Gods and Goddesses - Zeus, Apollo, Poseidon, etc. In addition to religious works, Classical artists also produced a range of three-dimensional sporting figures, depicting athletes of various kinds, including discus-throwers, runners, etc. Curiously, however, historical sculpture as practiced in Egypt and Assyria was almost unheard of in Ancient Greece. Important events were depicted in mythological terms, rather than through factual narrative.

- **The Hellenistic Period (c.323-27 BCE):** The "Greek" style of 3-D art is practiced across the Eastern Mediterranean.



Sepulchral monument of a dying Adonis, polychrome terracotta, Etruscan art from Tuscan, 250-100 BC

Hellenism, the outward spread of Greek culture to neighbouring areas of the eastern Mediterranean and beyond, traditionally begins with the death of Alexander the Great (323 BCE), when his huge empire was divided into three: Antigonos I (Monophthalmus) and the Antigonid dynasty took over Greece and Macedonia; Seleucus I (Nicator) and the Seleucid

dynasty controlled Anatolia, Mesopotamia and Persia; and Ptolemy I (Soter) and the Ptolemaic dynasty ruled Egypt.

Hellenistic Greek Sculpture introduced a number of changes to the type of art produced during the Classical era. To begin with, monumental sculpture was no longer created primarily to serve an austere religion, but became an important promotional tool to reinforce autocratic regimes set up throughout the region (in Pergamon, in Alexandria, and so on).

If the High Classical period set the standard for the High Renaissance, the era of Hellenistic art was the prototype for sculptors of the Mannerist and Baroque movements. During the era of Hellenism, following the death of Alexander the Great, the influence of Greek sculpture spread as far east as India, where it had a major impact on Indian sculpture- notably the Greco-Buddhist statues of the Gandhara school.

Male versus Female nudity in Greek Sculptures

Concept of heroic nudity

“Heroic” nude is an idealized visual representation of the male form that originated in Ancient Greece and has survived more or less intact until today. “It was fundamental to the Greek ethos, Greek culture, and antiquity,” says Patricia Lee Rubin, Renaissance art historian and professor emerita at New York University. It then passed on to its Roman adaptations in art and garden sculpture: the idealized male nude has been very important in art, and in people's looking at statues.

In Ancient Greece, the depiction of the nude male body was associated with specific social practices, such as the gymnasium and the symposium. “The pride in the naked body separated the elites from the commoners, men from women, and Greeks from foreigners. In short, nudity in real life was an important focus for elite male Greek identity,” writes Jill Burke in the book *The Italian Renaissance Nude*.

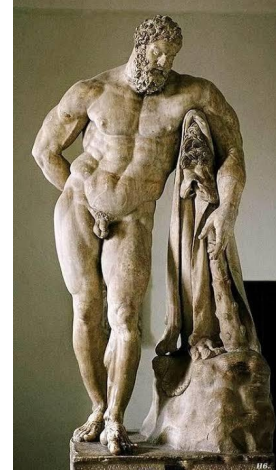
The **heroic nude** boils down to **three types**: the **boyish nude**, exemplified by the boy lovers of male gods (Ganymede, Hyacinth) and Cupid; **slender, athletic men**, like the doryphoros, the discobolus, or even the god Apollo; and, eventually, the more **muscular** “Hercules” type of physique.



Ganymede



Apollo



Hercules

The best known pose of male nude sculptures is the contrapposto. Translating “counterpoise,” it consists of depicting a human figure standing with most of its weight on one leg, with the other leg bent at the knee, which causes a tilt in hips, shoulders, and head.



Polykleitos' Doryphoros

Pioneered by the Greeks in the fifth century BCE, it evolved during the Hellenistic era to include a visible movement in the torso. Michelangelo brought the contrapposto to its zenith, moving the different muscle masses on different axes. His David, while more static than his

other nudes, is a famous example of this, and, in all, his work influenced baroque sculptors such as Bernini, who would also include torsion and twist in his nudes.

What's more, from the Renaissance onwards, it is common to see a heroic nude in an "arm akimbo" pose coupled with the bodyweight resting on the opposite leg. In representation as in reality, it can balance or counterbalance a heavy load.



*Donatello, David, c. 1440. Bronze
Arm akimbo*

Other than the famous contrapposto, another stance typical of heroic nudity is the straddle-legged pose, usually portrayed from behind. It traces back to ancient Greece, usually in association with war gods, warriors, and workers, and it denotes physical prowess and forcefulness.

Juxtaposition of the female sculptures against the male

Ancient Greek sculptors curved nude male statues to show masculine and power of the ideal male. Ancient Greek people worshiped the power of male can be seen in many places. Generals who led their armies and won the battle were always regarded as heroes of their country, such as Heracles and Achilles in Greek mythologies. Athletes who won the Olympic games were also honored by Greek people. Ancient Greek people thought these males became heroes because of their power. Under this situation, Greek sculptors curved apparent muscles on male sculptures without coverings to show their power and imply that they are heroes. However, things were totally different about female sculptures. In ancient Greece, people usually connect female nudity with sex, which was unacceptable in tradition Greek culture, especially when it involved into religious cult.

The need to justify female nudity while male nudity was considered commonplace already reflects Greek ideas about gender. For a man to appear naked conferred his power, his strong body and equally strong mind, while for a woman to appear naked would be indecent and confer immodesty. It is important to remember that the ancient Greeks viewed man and woman as dichotomies. One was defined as being the opposite of the other. As men were considered the dominant members of society women were the ones being defined as opposite; yet, interestingly enough, still defined as the “other”. In the words of Nanette Salomon, “the culturally constructed terms of femininity and masculinity in the ancient world were mutually dependent and reflexive fabrications whose definition depended upon their socially assigned differences, one from the other”. As the opposite of men, women were viewed as incapable of participating in the male sphere. Before the creation of Aphrodite of Knidos of Praxiteles, all the female statues were partly all fully clothed, and nearly no one tried to show the “ideal” female body figure through sculptures. Stansbury-O’Donnell believes that this sculpture of Aphrodite was Praxiteles’ innovation in Greek art and society.

This sculpture challenged the traditional Greek thoughts about the female body and also started a new era of female sculptures in the art field. Ironically, although people in Kos it is the nude version that has been copied and preserved until today. To some extent, Praxiteles’ Aphrodite forced ancient Greek people to think about female social status and urged the improvement of female social status in ancient Greece.

Artwork both influenced and reflected Greek behavior of the time period. Women were treated as vessels for children, not as human beings capable of aggressive sexuality. In fact, the common practice of pederasty was often used as a venue of sexual release for Greek men, while the nonsexual realm of childbearing and rearing was relegated to their wives.

Aphrodite of Knidos became the center of great controversy due to the fact that even partial nudity was rare in Greek art before the late fifth century BC: the only times female body parts were revealed was when women were victims of violence or represented as prostitutes.

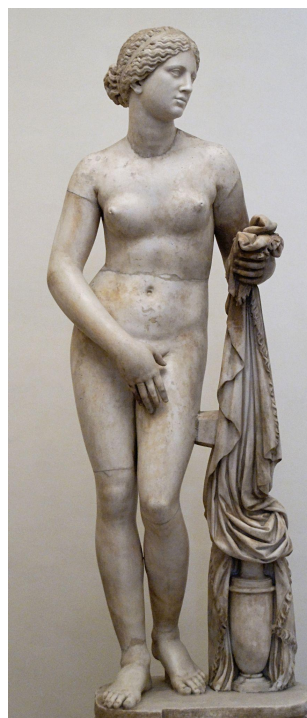
Thus, the nude sculpture of Aphrodite needed to be censored. For example, the genitals were not represented, non-existent. Specifically, Greek textual records show that female sexuality was rejected and there was a clear revulsion toward female genitalia when looking at the negative connotations depicted in the text towards menstruation and childbirth. Females were even considered as “polluting and dangerous to men”, and there were even taboos associated with touching menstruating women, or women who had recently given birth; even nursing milk was considered as pollution to men if it happened to touch their skin.

Additionally, female genitalia was referred to as “*aidoia*” or shameful parts. This was because women at the time had a relatively low social rank, only seemed as slightly higher than the status of a slave. Clearly, there was no way the Greek society would have been able to readily accept any form of female nudity as a form of art rather than as something degrading or of sexual nature.

In addition to censorship of the female genitalia, Praxiteles also needed some sort of excuse for portraying the Knidian Aphrodite in nude since only men could be portrayed as nude without question. Thus, Praxiteles created Aphrodite in a pose with her head turned to the side and hand covering the body with props of a water jar and bath towel, to suggest that the goddess just stepped out of her bath and had been caught in a momentary state of complete surprise. Such a depiction creates an image of voyeur, viewing Aphrodite's nakedness as a forbidden pleasure for viewers. Yet, the creation of such a work of art was possible because women, especially Aphrodite, were still respected in the realm of religion. Because Aphrodite is the Goddess of love whose image was found in many places, she was accepted as a figure of respect to the people of the time, a figure to which families would often give rich offerings to or pay homage.

CASE STUDIES

1. Aphrodite of Knidos (Classical Period)



Aphrodite of Knidos, Praxiteles, Circa 400 BCE, Marble

One of the most notable aspects of the Knidian Aphrodite is her pose. Considered the first of its type, this sculpture established the positioning of the hand over the pubis, now referred to as the pudica—or modest—pose. This offered a way for sculptors to depict female nudity in a

way considered chaste. Women in this pose were thought to be unwilling participants, and any sensuality found in the pose was considered somewhat unintentional. This pose also has the unspoken yet obvious side effect of directing attention towards a woman's pubis; a pubis that was often curiously devoid of both hair and any indication of a vulva. Lack of pubic hair can be explained by the common Greek practice of depilation, but the lack of visible genitalia is much more telling. In a culture known for carefully sculpting male genitals, a simple cleft made people shy away. Most scholars shun the idea that a realistic pubis was seen as aesthetically unappealing, and the most prominent theories today center around female genitalia being viewed as sexually aggressive. Women being aggressive, let alone sexually aggressive, was heavily discouraged and punished in Greek society.

While the pudica pose is one of the most obvious indicators of Greek kyriarchal gender ideals, every carefully placed limb, cocked hip, and bent shoulder of the Knidian Aphrodite contributes to the sense of modesty and sensuality, and to a sort of protective fear. For example, the figure has a hunched gesture. The slight droop of her right shoulder and the upward shift of the left, paired with the frontward tilt of her head all create the sense of a woman shying away from the gaze of the viewer.

2. Aphrodite of Delos (Hellenistic Period)

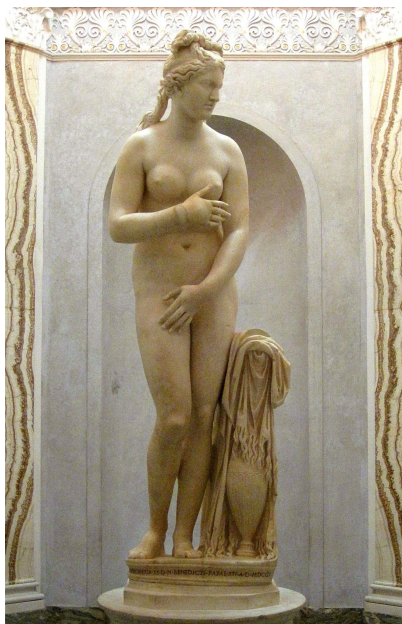


Aphrodite of Delos with Pan and Eros, Anonymous, circa 100 BCE, Marble

The marble group of Aphrodite, Pan and Eros, preserves three interacting figures which are original Greek creations that have survived and there are no known copies of it. The meaning and the mood of the sculpture can be interpreted without almost no ambiguity and conjecture. Aphrodite is plump; the nipples are incised and remarkably prominent and her body and face were highly polished so as to give the whole figure a soft, warm and fleshy render. Traces of red paint have been found in her combed and tied up hair to make it more realistic. While her left hand covers her genitalia (Pudica Pose), she holds her sandals in her right hand, raised, seemingly trying to slap Pan with it. However her tilted head and her smile gives a jesteral tone to the scenario and Aphrodite is friendly rather than outraged and teasing rather than serious. In short, she is friendly rather than outraged. Attempting to seduce the goddess, Pan represents lust and is almost beastly in nature. He clasps one hand around her arm while his other arm embraces her back. His right leg seems to be advancing to brush her ankle. The stump that projects between the two figures functions as a stabilizer but can be read as Pan's thrusting thigh when viewed from the front. A laughing Eros hovers between them, like a bridge, partly drawing them together and partly separating them, allied with neither.

In the delian group, Pan attempts to playfully draw Aphrodite's dimpled hand away. The purely religious gesture of the Knidia is deliberately satirised and therefore takes on a more secular meaning. The sculpture reveals the dynamics of seduction even though it has no mythological source or precedent.

3. Venus de Medici and Capitoline Venus



*Capitoline Venus, Praxiteles, circa 200-300 BCE,
Marble*



*Venus de' Medici, Anonymous, circa 100 BCE,
Marble*

While the Knidia only uses one hand for the purpose of concealment, Venus de Medici and Capitoline Venus both extend one of their hands across their breasts and the second lowered over the pubic region. According to J.J. Bernoulli, Aphrodite of Knidos embodies a naive, beautiful rapture but Medici and Capitoline exhibit shame and consciousness. He labeled the gesture of their hands the “pudica gesture” suggesting that instead of conveying the innocent modesty of Knidia, they are now intent on further covering their body as if they are aware that the exposure is inappropriate and indecent. In other words, they know that they are being watched.

CONCLUSION

After the fall of the Greek empire and the rise of the Roman empire (146 BC), the Romans adopted the culture and art traditions within the ancient Greeks. For the Romans, the art of the Greeks surpassed their own and spread quickly around their vast empire and left traces for future generations to uncover. Much like the Ancient Romans, Britain duplicated Art from antiquity was soon unearthed and rediscovered. Forgotten for centuries, in the 1500's these fractures of masterpieces inspired Renaissance painters and sculptors like Leonardo da Vinci and Michelangelo. The art of the Renaissance spread the influence of Greek art throughout Europe. During the 1600's the influence of Greek art extended beyond sculpture and painting. Creating movement, drama, human figurative form, and action of life and living flesh. Artist Peter Paul Rubens has depicted and had been directly influenced by ancient Greek art and kept art alive in new forms for centuries of its kind. Art up to the Greeks had been abstract and formal, while from the Greeks onwards it was based upon realism and to create realism through the capture of the essence of a form was still very strong in the Renaissance. The pudica pose which has its origins in the various Greek sculptural depictions of Aphrodite was adopted by various artists from different periods ranging from Botticelli to Rembrandt to Picasso.

Italian artists such as Titian, however, began depicting female nudes in real earnest in the 16th century, sometimes using them as an evocation of a lost Golden Age, in scenes other than narrative history paintings, where landscape came to play a much more prominent role than in previous paintings. With the 17th century, a somewhat more naturalistic depiction of the nude started to be seen, in such Baroque paintings as Artemisia Gentileschi's *Susanna and the Elders*, or (more well-known) the art of Caravaggio; here sensual male nudity comes to the fore, in highly dramatic nude works such as *David*.

Near the mid and latter end of the 19th century, portrayal of female nudity became more provocative and not limited to mythological or oriental subjects. As the bourgeoisie began to rise and gain power against absolute monarchy near the mid nineteenth century, Couture created his most famous work to reflect such changes in French society in 1847, *The Romans of Decadence*. The painting became one of the most popular Salon paintings in the entire nineteenth Century.

In contemporary art, with our modern knowledge from Freudian psychology of submerged (or somewhat acknowledged) sexual urges just beneath the surface of human life, depictions of nudity seem more and more often to be deliberately obscuring the fine line between art and pornography. Needless to say, the male body is articulated variously in artistic representations. More often than not, continuing to be represented as freely as it is in the social lens of its viewership. To associate nudity exclusively with sexual activity or sexual meaning is counterproductive when it comes to taking control of the psychological impact of the same on the human brain. A nude can be highly sexual or not at all sexual, just as a clothed figure can be highly alluring or non-sexual as well. It is essential to increase the acceptance of realist depictions of women in art, which would by extension help female nudism become a form of expressing ideas and messages rather than a form of sexuality. The mystification surrounding the female body continues to have a detrimental impact on their treatment in the society. By being more aware of the aspects of visual imagery that influence the ways we view gender, we can more easily challenge the bigoted social norms.

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List of Artworks

1. Greek amphora, Attica, fourth century BC
2. Marble base for a Kouros, Circa 510 BC
3. Centaur and Lapith, Metope of Parthenon, Circa 447 - 446 BC
4. Ganymede, Bertel Thorvaldsen, 1817
5. Apollo Belvedere , Anonymous, Circa AD 120–140
6. Farnese Hercules, Glykon, reproduced from the original by Lysippos, Circa 216 AD
7. The Dying Gladiator, Anonymous, Circa 323-31 BC
8. David, Donatello, Circa 1440-1460
9. Aphrodite of Knidos, Praxiteles, Circa 400 BCE,
10. Aphrodite of Delos with Pan and Eros, Anonymous, circa 100 BCE,
11. Capitoline Venus, Praxiteles, circa 200-300 BCE,
12. Venus de' Medici, Anonymous, circa 100 BCE,
13. Augustus of Prima Porta, anonymous, 1st Century AD
14. The Calydonian Boar Hunt, Peter Paul Reubens, 1612
15. The judgement of Paris, Peter Paul Reubens, 1635
16. The birth of Venus, Sandro botecelli, 1480

